Beyond Boundaries: The CLEAR Change Framework vs. OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking

Introduction

In a business world defined by rapid change and complex human dynamics, leaders often find themselves navigating a maze of frameworks in search of effective transformation. Many existing approaches to change – from **Organizational Behavior Management (OBM)** to the **Behavior Change Wheel (BCW)** to **Design Thinking** – offer pieces of the puzzle. Yet each tends to focus on a specific domain: OBM zeroes in on employee behaviors within organizations, BCW is rooted in individual behavior change science, and Design Thinking drives product or service innovation. Enter the **CLEAR Change Framework**, a comprehensive methodology created by *Erik Bohjort* (Licensed Psychologist, *Leg. Psykolog*) that aspires to transcend these boundaries. CLEAR integrates the strengths of behavioral science, management, and design into a broader, more holistic foundation for change.

This whitepaper provides a detailed comparison of CLEAR with OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking. It speaks to business stakeholders and transformation leaders in practical, inspirational terms – balancing credibility with vision. We will explore how CLEAR aligns with each of these influential frameworks while expanding beyond their limits. By the end, you will see why CLEAR is not just another tool, but a unifying approach that can *spark meaningful change across systems, strategies, and people's hearts and minds*.

(Crediting: Erik Bohjort, Licensed Psychologist and creator of the CLEAR Framework.)

Overview of the Frameworks

To set the stage, let's briefly summarize the four frameworks at the center of this discussion – what they are, what they're best at, and where they typically apply. This will help illuminate how CLEAR builds upon each of them:

The CLEAR Change Framework

CLEAR is a cutting-edge change framework developed to address transformation at **every level – from individual habits to organizational culture to broader systems**. As a holistic approach, CLEAR is not an acronym tied to a rigid sequence, but rather a philosophy that emphasizes: **systems thinking, strategic alignment, deep psychological insight, and iterative learning**. In practice, CLEAR provides a *cohesive foundation* from which various change tools (behavioral, design, or managerial) can be employed as needed. Erik Bohjort, drawing on his expertise in behavioral psychology and business consulting, designed CLEAR to be **flexible across contexts** – it has been used in corporate change initiatives, public sector behavior programs, product development, and beyond.

Key characteristics of CLEAR include:

- **Broader Scope:** It simultaneously considers the *systemic context* (e.g. organizational structures, market forces) and the *human factors* (individual motivations, team dynamics) in a change effort.
- **Strategic Alignment:** CLEAR starts by aligning any change initiative with the organization's overarching mission and strategy, ensuring relevance and buy-in at the highest level.
- **Psychological Insight:** Grounded in behavioral science and psychology, it digs into *why* people behave as they do. By understanding cognitive biases, emotional drivers, and what might be *preventing the target group from doing the right thing*, CLEAR uncovers root causes of resistance or inertia svt.se. As Bohjort notes, *"the best solutions come when [you've] understood what prevents the target group from doing right"* svt.se – a philosophy at the core of CLEAR.
- **Iterative Learning:** Rather than a one-and-done plan, CLEAR employs an *adaptive cycle* of action and reflection. It encourages pilot programs, feedback loops, and continuous improvement, much like an ongoing conversation with the organization. Each iteration yields insights, which inform adjustments in strategy or execution.

In essence, CLEAR acts as an **umbrella framework**. Under this umbrella, one might selectively use an OBM technique (e.g. a reward system for employees), a BCW analysis (to diagnose behavioral barriers), or a Design Thinking workshop (to prototype a solution), but all within a unifying, purpose-driven change strategy. CLEAR's promise is the *freedom to draw on any method without being constrained by it*. It strives to keep the **"big picture"** in focus – ensuring that changes at the micro level roll up into meaningful macro outcomes, and vice versa.

Organizational Behavior Management (OBM)

Organizational Behavior Management (OBM) is a well-established approach that applies behavioral psychology in workplaces to improve performance and efficiency. Born from the science of behavior (a sub-discipline of Applied Behavior Analysis), OBM focuses on **observable behaviors in organizational settings** and how to influence them. Practitioners of OBM assess the work environment and **alter it to encourage desired employee behaviors** – for example, by tweaking antecedents (triggers or cues before a behavior) and consequences (rewards or feedback after a behavior) en.wikipedia.org. The idea is that by changing what *happens around* the employee, you can reliably change the employee's actions.

OBM is **highly practical and data-driven**. It often involves identifying key behaviors that impact business outcomes (sales calls made, safety checks performed, etc.), measuring them, and then implementing interventions like incentive programs, feedback systems, or process changes to reinforce positive behaviors. Research shows

that such **interventions linked to the organization's goals** can boost productivity, safety, and morale en.wikipedia.org. In fact, OBM consultants "focus on assessing and changing the work environment to improve employee performance and workplace culture" bacb.com.

Strengths of OBM: It is laser-focused on behavior change *within organizations*. Because it's rooted in behavioral science, OBM techniques tend to be **evidence-based and measurable**. For instance, if a company wants to reduce errors on an assembly line, an OBM approach might set up a system of immediate feedback and small rewards for error-free work segments, directly linking actions to consequences. This specificity and clarity make OBM interventions relatively straightforward to implement and track. Over time, OBM has built credibility (ethos) through numerous case studies demonstrating improved performance in business settings.

Limitations of OBM: By design, OBM stays *within the confines of the workplace behavior*. It usually targets **employee behaviors and managerial practices**, meaning its scope is somewhat narrow – it might not explicitly address **broader strategic questions** (e.g. is the organization even pursuing the right goals?) or external factors (market changes, customer behaviors) beyond the workplace. OBM also tends to emphasize extrinsic motivation (reinforcements and consequences); it may underplay intrinsic motivation, creativity, or emotional buy-in. Culturally, some employees might feel like cogs in a machine if OBM is applied insensitively. In short, OBM is a powerful *specialized tool* – akin to a precision laser – but it's not a full blueprint for large-scale change. CLEAR acknowledges the value of OBM's precision but situates it within a broader canvas of change that also accounts for culture, strategy, and human inspiration.

The Behavior Change Wheel (BCW)

The **Behavior Change Wheel (BCW)** is a comprehensive framework from academic research, designed to guide the development of behavior change interventions. Created by Susan Michie and colleagues in 2011, BCW was born out of a rigorous review of 19 prior behavior change models pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov

. At its core lies the **COM-B model**, which posits that behavior (B) is influenced by an individual's **Capability**, **Opportunity**, and **Motivation**. These three conditions form a hub (the COM-B system) that any successful behavior change must address implementationscience.biomedcentral.com. Surrounding the hub, the BCW identifies **nine intervention functions** (types of strategies like Education, Persuasion, Training, Environmental restructuring, etc.) and **seven policy categories** that support these interventions implementationscience.biomedcentral.com. The framework essentially provides a **structured "wheel" of options** to consider when trying to change a specific behavior.

In practice, using the BCW involves a systematic process: define the behavior of interest in detail, diagnose what is lacking in Capability, Opportunity, or Motivation for that behavior, then select intervention functions (and policy measures, if relevant) that are known to address those specific deficits. For example, if employees are not adopting a new software tool, a BCW analysis might reveal a **Capability gap** (they lack knowledge or skills), suggesting an **Education** or **Training** intervention; it might also show an **Opportunity gap** (the old tool is still easier to access), suggesting need for **Environmental restructuring** (e.g. removing the old tool or making the new one more accessible). The BCW ensures that the intervention plan is **comprehensive and evidence-informed**, rather than based on guesswork.

Strengths of BCW: It is celebrated for its **comprehensiveness and scientific rigor**. Researchers have called the Behavior Change Wheel *"the most comprehensive and practically useful methodology available for developing behavior change interventions."* pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov

Because it synthesizes insights from many theories, it gives change practitioners a 360-degree view of the behavioral challenge. Nothing important is left out: psychological capability, social and physical environment, conscious and automatic motivation – all get examined. The BCW's structured approach adds logical clarity (logos) to designing interventions, which is especially valuable in fields like public health, policy, or any context where specific behaviors (e.g. medication adherence, recycling, safe driving) are the target. It also provides a common language for interdisciplinary teams (e.g. psychologists, project managers, policymakers) to collaborate on behavior change plans.

Limitations of BCW: For all its thoroughness, the BCW can be **complex and technical**. It was devised by academics and often *used in research or expert-driven projects*, which means that business leaders or lay practitioners may find it dense or require training to apply correctly. Its focus is typically at the **individual or community behavior level** – one behavior at a time – rather than large-scale organizational change or innovation processes. In a corporate setting, the BCW might help design a wellness program or a safety campaign, but on its own it doesn't encompass, say, reimagining a business model or shifting an entire organizational culture. Implementation can also be quite resource-intensive, as the BCW encourages a lot of upfront analysis. Finally, while BCW is great for *designing* interventions, it doesn't prescribe how to *manage* the change process over time; aspects like ongoing leadership engagement or adapting strategy are outside its scope. **CLEAR** leverages the **insights of BCW** – ensuring that any behavioral intervention is grounded in science – but situates them in a *larger change management context*. In CLEAR, one might use the BCW to diagnose a specific behavioral hurdle as part of a project, but then also address leadership alignment, cross-team coordination, and iteration, which is beyond the BCW's own toolkit.

Design Thinking

Design Thinking is a popular and creative approach originally developed in the design and innovation world, now widely adopted across industries to solve problems in a **user-centric** way. Unlike OBM and BCW, which come from psychology and behavior science, Design Thinking has its roots in the practices of designers (product designers, architects, etc.) tackling complex problems. Its core premise is simple yet powerful: to design effective solutions, one must deeply understand the **end-user's needs and experiences** and then **iteratively prototype** ideas, learning and refining by testing those ideas with users.

Design Thinking is often summarized by a series of phases or steps. While different versions exist (ranging from three-step models to six-step models), a common **5-step formulation** is:

1. **Empathize** – Research and understand the users or stakeholders. (Who are we designing for? What do they feel, think, need?)
2. **Define** – Clearly articulate the problem or insight based on user needs (framing the challenge).
3. **Ideate** – Generate a range of creative solutions or concepts, often in collaborative brainstorming sessions.
4. **Prototype** – Build scrappy, low-fidelity versions of one or more ideas (a draft app screen, a mock process, a storyboard, etc.).
5. **Test** – Try out prototypes with users, gather feedback, and learn what works and what doesn't. (Then often cycle back to Ideate or Prototype based on what was learned – hence an iterative loop.)

This process is anchored in a **human-centered mindset**: empathy is paramount. Harvard Business School describes design thinking as *"a mindset and approach to problem-solving and innovation anchored around human-centered design."* online.hbs.edu It deliberately focuses on solutions (what *will* help the user) rather than fixating on problems online.hbs.edu – a subtle shift that encourages teams to envision a better future state rather than get bogged down. Design Thinking also provides a **standardized innovation process** that non-designers can follow to tackle all sorts of challenges online.hbs.edu, not just product design. It's been embraced by companies globally as a way to spur creativity and break out of old thinking patterns. From designing a new app interface to reimagining a customer service journey, the methodology is highly *versatile*.

Strengths of Design Thinking: Its greatest strength is **emotional resonance and engagement (pathos)** – it puts people (users, customers, employees) at the heart of any solution. This tends to produce ideas that really *connect* with the target audience,

generating excitement and buy-in. The iterative prototyping means you don't bet everything on a grand plan; instead, you experiment and refine in a *low-risk, low-cost manner* until you find something that truly works. This fosters a culture of innovation and learning. Design Thinking also breaks silos – typically, cross-functional teams work together in workshops, which builds a shared understanding and commitment. It excels at generating novel, user-friendly solutions to specific problems, and it's **action-oriented** – within a short time, you go from ideas to tangible prototypes. This momentum can be energizing for organizations.

Limitations of Design Thinking: On its own, Design Thinking is **not a comprehensive change management framework**. It's best suited for *developing a product, service, or specific solution* rather than orchestrating broad organizational change. One could design a better employee onboarding experience using Design Thinking, for example, but ensuring that new process is rolled out across a global company and sustained over years would require additional change management efforts beyond just the design workshops. Design Thinking doesn't inherently focus on the *scientific understanding of behavior* – so it might come up with a clever solution, but miss some deeper behavioral insight that a framework like BCW or OBM would catch (like an unspoken incentive or fear that prevents adoption). Also, some critics note that if overused as a buzzword, Design Thinking sessions can lead to lots of sticky notes but not necessarily long-term results; without alignment to strategy, prototypes might solve the wrong problem. Finally, it generally addresses *one challenge at a time* – it's not meant to handle system-wide transformation with many interconnected moving parts. **CLEAR** appreciates the **user-focused creativity of Design Thinking** and actually embeds a similar iterative, co-creative ethos. However, CLEAR ensures that those design efforts are **strategically targeted** (so we're solving the right problems) and followed through with systematic change execution (so solutions aren't left on the whiteboard, but implemented and scaled).

Comparative Analysis: CLEAR vs. OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking

Now that we've outlined each framework, let's compare and contrast them directly. We'll examine both their theoretical orientation and how they play out in practice. The goal is to illustrate how **CLEAR serves as an integrating "whole"** compared to these "part" approaches. While OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking each contribute vital perspectives, CLEAR combines their strengths and fills their gaps to enable more **transformative, sustained change**.

Big-Picture Scope vs. Specialized Focus

One of the most striking differences is the **scope of change** each framework is designed to address. **CLEAR is deliberately big-picture and holistic**, whereas the other frameworks zoom in on specific layers:

- **CLEAR** looks at *multi-level change*. It can simultaneously consider **systemic factors** (like organizational structure, market conditions, or policy environment), **group and cultural factors** (team dynamics, corporate culture norms), and **individual factors** (personal motivation and behavior). For example, if a company is undergoing an AI transformation, CLEAR would guide leaders to align the change with company strategy (system level), ensure teams have the right mindset and training (group/individual level), adjust processes or incentives (organizational level), and possibly even consider customer behavior changes (external context). There's a conscious *zoom in and zoom out* with CLEAR – ensuring no critical element is overlooked.
- **OBM** focuses mainly at the *organizational and individual behavior level within a workplace*. It is **context-bound to the organization's internal environment**. OBM might guide you to implement a performance feedback system on a factory floor or a sales team incentive plan. It *will not* typically address how the market or community interacts with those changes, nor will it question the overarching strategic direction – those are considered outside its scope. In short, OBM is an **operational tool** to tweak behavior in service of existing strategy and goals en.wikipedia.org.
- **BCW** focuses on the *behavioral level*, usually of individuals (or sometimes specific groups or populations). It's **highly granular** about one behavior at a time – e.g., increasing usage of a safety helmet among construction workers, or getting customers to adopt paperless billing. BCW does acknowledge broader context (through "Opportunity" in COM-B and policy categories in the outer wheel), but it treats them as influences on the behavior rather than things to change at a strategic level. If using BCW in an organization, you would typically pick a particular behavior (like employees using a new software) and design interventions for that. The organization's larger system (like its hierarchy, culture, or strategy) is not the primary focus, except insofar as it affects the target behavior.
- **Design Thinking** generally scopes to a *defined problem area or project*. For instance, "How might we improve the onboarding experience for new hires?" or "What new service can we create to better serve customer need X?" It's **project-centric**. While it may lead to innovative solutions that have broader implications, Design Thinking starts with a specific user problem and ends with a tested prototype for that problem. It doesn't inherently scale up to say, "How do we transform our entire organization's culture?" unless you break that into tangible sub-problems that fit the design sprint format.

CLEAR's Advantage in Scope: By being broad in scope, CLEAR ensures that **all levels of change are aligned**. It connects the dots from the *why* (strategic purpose) to the *what*

(specific behaviors or products) to the *how* (process and design). For example, CLEAR would not only generate an innovative solution via design thinking techniques, it would also ensure that solution fits the company's strategy, that employees are behaviorally inclined to adopt it (maybe using OBM or BCW insights), and that the organization's systems are ready to support it. This prevents the common pitfall of siloed initiatives – e.g. a cool pilot project that fails to roll out company-wide, or a behavior change campaign that isn't tied into business objectives. CLEAR keeps everything **cohesive and moving in the same direction** (hence "strategic alignment" as a core principle).

Methodology and Process: Rigor vs. Creativity – Why Not Both?

Each framework has a distinct method for approaching change, with its own flavor of **logic and creativity**. Let's contrast them:

- **Organized Behavioral Interventions (OBM):** OBM's process is analytical and interventionist. It often starts with **measurement** – identify a baseline of the behavior (e.g., current performance metrics). Then set a goal and apply a **behavioral intervention** (like change the antecedents: provide training or clearer instructions; or change consequences: give bonuses, feedback, etc.). Then **measure again**, and tweak as needed. It's essentially a PDCA (Plan-Do-Check-Act) cycle grounded in reinforcement theory. OBM can be very methodical: define target behavior, choose intervention based on behavioral principles, implement, evaluate results quantitatively, rinse and repeat. This gives OBM a strong **logos** component – it's logical and data-driven. However, it doesn't inherently include a creative brainstorming phase or user empathy phase; the solutions tend to be known behavioral techniques (which are effective, but not necessarily "out-of-the-box" novel).
- **Systematic Analysis and Planning (BCW):** The BCW methodology is **diagnostic and structured**. It begins with a thorough *behavioral diagnosis* (COM-B analysis), which is akin to a doctor examining a patient before writing a prescription. Then it moves to a *mapping exercise* – selecting from the wheel of intervention functions those that match the diagnosed needs. This is a highly logical design process: one could almost fill in a worksheet to ensure all considerations are addressed. Creativity enters in choosing *how* to implement the intervention functions, but BCW itself doesn't dictate a brainstorming method – it leverages existing scientific knowledge about which interventions work for which deficits. As a result, BCW-driven projects tend to produce **well-reasoned, evidence-backed intervention plans**, but they might not feel as openly experimental or collaborative as design thinking sessions.
- **Creative Iteration (Design Thinking):** Design Thinking's methodology is the opposite of top-down analysis; it is **exploratory and generative**. It thrives on **divergent thinking** (in ideation) followed by **convergent testing** (in prototyping).

There is a lot of **post-it note creativity**, storytelling, sketching, and trying things out with real people to see what resonates. It's less about choosing from established techniques and more about *inventing or co-creating new approaches* tailored to the user's context. Design thinking sessions often encourage wild ideas and defer judgment early on – which can lead to breakthrough insights or solutions nobody initially suspected. The iterative loop means even failures are framed positively as learning (which is great for morale and innovation culture). This methodology scores high on **pathos** – engaging people's passion and empathy – and on practicality in the sense of making ideas tangible quickly.

- **Integrated and Iterative (CLEAR):** The CLEAR framework's methodology is a **hybrid, leveraging both rigorous analysis and creative design**. You might say CLEAR runs on **both sides of the brain** – analytical and empathetic. In a CLEAR-driven engagement, one could expect phases or components that look like:
    - **Clarification and Alignment:** Much like a consulting project kickoff, CLEAR would start by clarifying the vision of change, the strategic objectives, and the metrics of success (bringing in that logos-driven clarity). It ensures leadership and stakeholders are on the same page about *what "success" looks like* for the change.
    - **Insight Gathering:** Here's where **psychological insight and data** come in. CLEAR would employ techniques from behavioral science (possibly a COM-B analysis like BCW, or employee surveys, observations, interviews) to understand the current state – the pain points, the enablers and blockers of change. This is analogous to the Empathize phase of design thinking but augmented with behavioral diagnostics. For instance, CLEAR might identify that *employees are not adopting a new process because of social norms (opportunity) and fear of failure (motivation)* – insights that come from psychological expertise.
    - **Co-Creation and Design:** Next, CLEAR typically facilitates a creative solution design phase. This is where **Design Thinking-style workshops or brainstorming** can occur. With the insights in hand, diverse stakeholders might ideate interventions or solutions. The big difference is, under CLEAR, this creativity is **targeted** – it's not just innovation for its own sake, it's innovation in service of the strategic goals and informed by behavioral science. We might generate ideas for training programs, new tools, policy changes, communication campaigns – nothing is off-limits, because CLEAR isn't tied to only one type of solution.
    - **Implementation with Behavioral Focus:** As solutions are chosen, CLEAR drives implementation in a way that **pays attention to behavior change principles**. This is where OBM-like or BCW-like tactics come in. If one of

the chosen solutions is a new workflow, CLEAR would ensure that it's rolled out with proper reinforcement (maybe an OBM expert helps set up feedback loops), and that any capability gaps are addressed (BCW-style training or environment changes). Essentially, CLEAR orchestrates the *deployment* of changes using whichever approach fits best – training (if skill is needed), re-structuring (if environment is an issue), incentives (if motivation is an issue), etc., all drawn from established science.

- **Iterative Feedback & Learning:** After implementation, CLEAR emphasizes **reviewing outcomes and learning**. Metrics identified at the start are measured. Qualitative feedback is listened to and gathered from those affected. The organization deliberately reflects on "What's working? What isn't? How? Why?" This reflective step is akin to both OBM's Check phase and Design Thinking's Test phase. Crucially, CLEAR treats this not as a final audit but as *fuel for the next iteration*. The framework encourages making tweaks or even pivoting to a new strategy if initial assumptions were off. It embeds an **agile mindset** in change management – continuous improvement rather than a finite project.

By blending these steps, CLEAR manages to be **both systematic and creative**. It doesn't rely on inspiration alone, nor on analysis alone, but balances the two. For example, an organization might *feel* (pathos) the excitement of a hackathon to generate ideas (a dose of Design Thinking) and at the same time *know* (logos) that those ideas are built on solid behavioral evidence and will be rigorously followed through (thanks to OBM/BCW principles).

Flexibility and Applicability

Another dimension to compare is **where and how each framework can be applied** – and how flexible they are in adapting to different contexts:

- **OBM's Applicability:** OBM is best suited for **business operations, employee performance, and safety initiatives**. It has been successfully used in factories, sales organizations, hospitals (for staff behavior), and any environment where improving *specific measurable behaviors* leads to better results. However, try to apply OBM to, say, **customer behavior change or community programs**, and it's not an obvious fit – that's beyond typical OBM. OBM also assumes you have **authority or leverage in a given environment** (since you often implement consequences or change surroundings); it's not as useful if you're trying to influence people voluntarily outside a managed setting.
- **BCW's Applicability:** The BCW shines in **public health, policy, and program design** (e.g., designing a smoking cessation program, or increasing public transit use) and can be used for internal programs like improving workplace behaviors

too. It's fairly **universal to any behavior**, but it requires **expertise to use properly**. It's flexible in theory (because any behavior fits COM-B), but not very *adaptive* in process – one usually follows the prescribed steps. BCW might not be the go-to in fast-paced business settings that demand quick prototyping; it is more at home in planned interventions, research-driven projects, and scenarios where a *systematic approach is valued over speed*.

- **Design Thinking's Applicability:** Design Thinking is extremely **flexible in domain** – it can be used for designing a new app interface, improving an HR policy, creating a marketing campaign, or even for personal development coaching. Its strength is that it's **accessible to non-experts** (any team can be taught the process) and can be done relatively quickly in workshop formats or sprints. However, its effectiveness depends on the *problem framing*. If the challenge isn't well-defined or is too broad ("make our culture more innovative"), a design sprint might flounder. It's best when you can frame a human-centered question. Also, design thinking won't automatically scale a small prototype to a full rollout – you need other frameworks or management processes to take a successful pilot and implement it organization-wide.
- **CLEAR's Applicability:** CLEAR was explicitly designed to be **applicable across a wide range of contexts** – corporate transformations, organizational development, behavior change programs, innovation projects, even social change initiatives. Because it *integrates multiple approaches*, CLEAR can flex to what the situation demands. In a top-down strategic change (like a merger integration or culture change), CLEAR provides the guiding structure to align stakeholders and manage the complex moving parts, while still remembering to consider individual behaviors and using creative problem-solving for issues that arise. In a grassroots change or a product innovation, CLEAR ensures the efforts tie back to strategy and that **behavioral enablers** are built-in so the innovation actually gets adopted and sustained. Essentially, CLEAR can act as a **"meta-framework"** – if a scenario calls for a very specific technique, CLEAR will accommodate that technique within its umbrella. This means clients don't have to choose one framework and forego the others; with CLEAR they get a **tailored mix**. For example, a client might not know whether they need an OBM project to tweak employee habits, or a design thinking approach to rethink a service – with CLEAR, the engagement can evolve to include both: maybe start with design thinking to conceptualize a new service, then use OBM principles to train employees in delivering it and BCW logic to craft the customer behavior change strategy for adoption of the service. All the while, CLEAR keeps the effort coherent and aligned with the business goals.

Given this flexibility, CLEAR is particularly appealing to **transformation leads who face multi-faceted challenges**. In the real world, problems are rarely siloed. A single goal – say, improving sustainability in a company – may require changes in employee behavior (an OBM piece), changes in customer behavior (a BCW-informed public campaign piece), and new product designs (a Design Thinking piece). Rather than juggle three separate frameworks or consultants, a CLEAR approach provides one cohesive roadmap that **integrates all these layers seamlessly**.

Emotional Resonance and Cultural Change

A successful change is not only about processes and policies, but also about how people *feel* and *engage* with the change. This is where the ethos and pathos of each framework come into play:

- **OBM and Culture:** OBM, being behaviorist, doesn't explicitly address emotions or culture beyond how they manifest in behavior. It might indirectly improve morale (for example, employees often appreciate clear goals and feedback, which OBM provides) but it could also backfire if employees feel they are being micromanaged purely for metrics. OBM doesn't tell you how to inspire people or create meaning; it tells you how to get them to do specific actions via reinforcement. So on the emotional spectrum, OBM is fairly neutral or even mechanical. CLEAR takes OBM's outcomes and embeds them in a *meaningful narrative* – for instance, linking a behavior change program to a larger vision that employees find inspiring, thus adding that missing emotional layer.
- **BCW and Engagement:** BCW, being a framework to design interventions, similarly doesn't directly speak to inspiring people; it's more about logically ensuring the intervention components are in place. The emotional aspect would come from how you execute the interventions (e.g., what messaging you use in a persuasive campaign). BCW would ensure you include a "persuasion" function if motivation is low, but it doesn't craft the message for you. That's up to practitioners' creativity. So BCW is strong on *what boxes to check* (education, enablement, etc.) but not on the art of *how to win hearts*. CLEAR, on the other hand, explicitly values **psychological insight** – which includes understanding people's aspirations, fears, and values (emotional drivers). Thus, a CLEAR implementation would pay attention to not just *that* we need to persuade, but *how* to frame change in a way that resonates deeply with people's values (this is where Erik Bohjort's psychology background directly enriches CLEAR: elements of motivational interviewing, storytelling, nudging, etc., can be woven in to truly connect with participants on a human level).
- **Design Thinking and Mindset Shift:** Design Thinking excels at generating enthusiasm and optimism. When employees participate in a design thinking workshop, they often report feeling **more heard, more creative, and more**

connected to the outcome because they had a hand in shaping it. This is a cultural win – it builds a *can-do, experimental culture* at least in pockets. However, one workshop alone doesn't shift an entire culture. Many organizations struggle to move from a few innovation labs to a truly innovative culture. Design Thinking by itself won't change how a finance department operates or how leaders make decisions day-to-day outside of project work. CLEAR recognizes that **cultural change** is critical for long-term success. By engaging not just project teams but also leadership in the CLEAR process (remember, strategic alignment is key), it ensures that the *mindset* of iterative learning, empathy, and evidence-based action cascades upward and downward. Leaders in a CLEAR engagement learn to value experimentation and reflection (because they see the positive results), and employees see leaders walking the talk – over time this nurtures a culture more open to change and aligned with the CLEAR philosophy. In essence, CLEAR can act as a Trojan horse for culture change: by practicing its principles on a project, the organization *experiences a new way of working* that can then spread. It fuses the **inspirational spark** of design thinking with the *reinforcement strategies* of OBM to make new cultural norms stick.

Comparison Table: CLEAR vs. OBM, BCW, Design Thinking

To crystallize these comparisons, the table below summarizes key differences and overlaps between the CLEAR Change Framework and the other three frameworks:

Aspect	*CLEAR Change Framework*	*Organizational Behavior Management (OBM)*	*Behavior Change Wheel (BCW)*	*Design Thinking*
Primary Focus & Scope	Holistic, multi-level change. Addresses systems, organizational strategy, team dynamics, and individual behaviors in an integrated way. Applicable across industries and contexts (corporate, public sector, products, culture change).	Organizational behavior. Focuses on employee behaviors and workplace processes within an organization. Typically bounded to internal operations and performance metrics.	Individual behavior change. Focuses on specific behaviors (often health, safety, or habit-related) in a target population. Can be applied in organizations or communities for particular behavior outcomes.	Innovation and problem-solving. Focuses on user-centered product or service design and creative solutions to defined problems. Applied in projects (product development, service improvement, UX, etc.).
Core Principles & Approach	Integration and alignment: Combines strategic planning, behavioral science, and design iteration. Ensures change initiatives align with mission and uses data + empathy to drive decisions. Involves stakeholders at all levels for buy-in and insight.	Behavioral reinforcement: Based on applied behavior analysis. Uses antecedents and consequences (e.g. feedback, rewards) to shape behavior. Highly data-driven and goal-oriented. Straightforward cycle: measure behavior, intervene, re-measure.	COM-B model & intervention mapping: Uses a structured diagnostic (Capability, Opportunity, Motivation) to identify what's needed for change. Then selects from 9 intervention types (education, incentives, etc.) and supportive policies. Emphasizes comprehensive coverage of factors influencing behavior	Human-centered design process: Uses empathy, ideation, prototyping, and testing in an iterative loop. Emphasizes understanding the user's perspective deeply and co-creating solutions. Prioritizes rapid experimentation and feedback to refine ideas
Strengths	Broad and flexible: Adapts to any context; integrates the strengths of other frameworks. Ensures changes are strategically relevant, psychologically savvy, and continuously improved. Builds unity of purpose (leaders and teams pulling in same direction) and can address both technical and adaptive challenges.	Proven effective for performance: Clear, measurable interventions yield quick wins (e.g. productivity up, errors down). Scientific rigor from behaviorism – results are observable and repeatable. Great for operational improvements and aligning behaviors with organizational goals.	Comprehensive and evidence-based: Leaves no stone unturned – tackles all dimensions of behavior change (knowledge, environment, motivation). Provides a step-by-step method to design effective interventions, reducing guesswork. Backed by extensive research and validated in fields like health (e.g. more effective interventions when using BCW).	Highly creative and engaging: Sparks innovation and enthusiasm. Teams often feel empowered and inspired through participation. Quickly produces tangible prototypes, preventing analysis-paralysis. User adoption tends to be high for solutions because users' needs drive the design. Fosters a culture of empathy and agility.
Limitations	None inherent, but requires skilled facilitation and cross-disciplinary thinking. (CLEAR is broad – success depends on effectively orchestrating various tools and stakeholders.) As a newer, holistic approach, it may challenge traditional siloed roles initially.	Narrower scope: Not designed for strategic pivots or creative ideation; over-emphasis on extrinsic rewards can sometimes undermine intrinsic motivation. Doesn't directly address emotions or systemic change beyond the workplace microcosm. Can be seen as mechanistic if not coupled with vision/meaning.	Complexity and niche use: Can be difficult for non-experts to implement. Time-consuming upfront analysis. Typically addresses one behavior at a time – not a fit for broad culture or structural changes. Relies on proper execution of interventions (requires follow-through). Mostly used in expert-led projects rather than everyday business practice.	Scope and sustainment: Tends to tackle one design challenge at a time – may miss the bigger strategic picture. Outcomes (prototypes) require additional change management to implement at scale. Without integration of behavior science, solutions might be lovable but not lasting in changing habits. Risk of "innovation theater" if not tied to real strategy/execution.

(In the table above, CLEAR is portrayed as an overarching approach that avoids the pitfalls of the other three by being deliberately integrative. OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking each shine in specific arenas but have blind spots that CLEAR aims to fill.)

Practical Implementation: How a Project Differs Under Each Framework

To further illustrate the differences, consider a hypothetical but relatable challenge: **a mid-sized tech company "AlphaCorp" wants to become more agile and customer-centric**. This involves cultural change, process change, and perhaps new service offerings. Let's see how a project might unfold with each approach:

- **Using OBM alone:** AlphaCorp's leaders might identify specific employee behaviours to change – e.g., "developers should deploy code updates weekly instead of monthly." An OBM consultant would set up a system of goals and rewards for weekly deployments, provide feedback charts, and perhaps train managers to praise teams that achieve the new cadence. Over a few months, deployment frequency increases (a concrete behaviour change). However, OBM by itself might not delve into whether this behaviour truly improved customer centricity (it addressed speed, not necessarily customer insight), nor whether the broader organizational structure supports agility (maybe other processes are still bureaucratic). It tackled one piece of the puzzle effectively, but not the whole puzzle.
- **Using BCW alone:** A BCW approach might start by pinpointing a specific behaviour critical to customer-centricity, for instance "employees proactively seek customer feedback on features". Through COM-B analysis, they discover maybe *Motivation* is low (employees don't see personal benefit in extra customer communication) and *Opportunity* is lacking (no channel or time provided for that feedback). The intervention might include **Education/Persuasion** (workshops highlighting success stories of customer-driven development to boost motivation) and **Environmental restructuring** (setting up a formal customer feedback portal and allocating time each sprint to review feedback). This could yield a meaningful shift in that behaviour – more feedback loops with customers. But again, BCW kept the focus tight. It won't automatically streamline AlphaCorp's internal decision-making or generate new product ideas; it changed a behavior within the existing system.
- **Using Design Thinking alone:** A design thinking initiative at AlphaCorp might gather a cross-functional team to improve customer experience. They might **empathize** by interviewing customers, **define** the top customer pain points, **ideate** solutions (perhaps they conceptualize a new customer collaboration app), **prototype** a minimal version of it, and **test** with a pilot group of customers. This could lead to an exciting new tool or service that indeed boosts customer-centricity for that pilot group. Employees involved likely feel energized and see

what "customer-centric" means in action. However, if the rest of the company isn't on board, this could remain a side project. Scaling the new app company-wide, training all teams to use it, adjusting KPIs to value its usage – those steps are beyond standard design thinking and require management decisions (which might or might not happen). The cultural change to become more agile might not stick if only a small innovation team practiced it during the sprint.

- **Using CLEAR:** AlphaCorp would start with CLEAR by having leadership articulate *what being agile and customer-centric means for the business strategy* – perhaps it's to respond to market changes faster and increase customer satisfaction by 20%. The CLEAR approach would then *diagnose* current state: Are teams overly siloed (system issue)? Do employees fear taking risks (culture issue)? Do they lack tools to engage customers (capability issue)? Are incentives aligned to old metrics (strategy misalignment)? This insight phase might use surveys, interviews, maybe a COM-B analysis for key behaviours like "proactively seek customer feedback" and "frequent deployments". Armed with insights, CLEAR would facilitate co-creation across the company: some teams might run Design Thinking workshops to solve specific pain points (like prototyping that customer feedback app), management might redesign some processes or roles to reduce silos, HR might tweak incentives to reward customer-focused actions, and an OBM-style system of feedback might be introduced to reinforce the new behaviors (like dashboards showing customer satisfaction scores for each team, celebrated monthly). These various interventions would *all be part of one integrated plan*. CLEAR would coordinate the rollout – ensuring, for instance, that after the design thinking pilot proves the app works, resources are allocated to implement it company-wide (with training for everyone – covering capability), and leaders consistently communicate the importance of these changes (shaping social motivation). Over the next 6-12 months, CLEAR would have the company cycle through iterations: try changes in a few departments, learn from them, refine and expand. Relevant metrics like deployment frequency, customer satisfaction, and employee engagement would be tracked and shared transparently (reinforcing progress and keeping emotional momentum). By the end, AlphaCorp doesn't just have one new tool or one new behaviour – it has a *new operating rhythm* and culture. The desired agility and customer-centric mindset are reflected in everyday practices, supported by systems and embraced by people. CLEAR served as the conductor of an orchestra of changes – with OBM, BCW, and design instruments playing in harmony when appropriate.

Through this example, we see CLEAR in action as *a broader change orchestration*, whereas each other framework is like a skilled soloist on one part of the change.

Conclusion: CLEAR as a Unified, Human-Centered Foundation for Change

In comparing the CLEAR Change Framework with OBM, the Behaviour Change Wheel, and Design Thinking, a clear narrative emerges: **most change efforts require a blend of perspectives – behavioural, strategic, and creative**. Traditional frameworks often force organizations to choose a lane: "Should we focus on behaviour management? Or bring in design thinking? Or use an academic model?" This fragmented approach can leave leaders feeling uncertain and fragmented themselves. **CLEAR offers a way out of that dilemma**. It is built on the premise that *effective transformation is not about picking the right single tool, but about weaving together the right tools at the right time under a unifying vision*.

CLEAR distinguishes itself as a **broader, more holistic framework** – one that *aligns with and integrates the strengths* of frameworks like OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking, without being confined by their limits. It provides the **ethos of credibility** (grounded in Bohjort's behavioral science expertise and its reliance on proven methods), the **pathos of emotional resonance** (by always keeping people's experience and motivation in focus), and the **logos of logical structure** (through strategic alignment and iterative learning). In rhetorical terms, CLEAR speaks to the head and the heart: executives see the strategic sense (and results data) while employees and customers *feel* listened to, engaged, and energized by the change process.

For potential consultancy clients considering working with Erik Bohjort and the CLEAR framework, the implications are compelling:

- **You get a cohesive strategy** for change – not a patchwork of initiatives. CLEAR ensures that whether we're tweaking a workflow or inventing a new service, it all ladders up to your organizational goals and brand promise.
- **You gain flexibility and adaptability.** No matter if mid-project you discover a new challenge or an external shift (say a market disruption), CLEAR's iterative nature means we adapt the plan intelligently, incorporating perhaps a new BCW analysis or a fresh design sprint as needed. We're not stuck on a railroad track; we're navigating with agility.
- **Your people are part of the journey.** Change is not imposed on them as an abstract mandate; through CLEAR's inclusive approach (workshops, feedback loops, transparent goals), employees become co-creators. This builds trust and enthusiasm – the fuel for sustainable change. As one might infer from Bohjort's work, when people understand *why* change is needed and have a hand in shaping *how* it's executed, they are far more committed to making it succeed svt.se.
- **Results go beyond metrics – they transform culture.** Certainly, CLEAR is accountable to hard outcomes (KPIs, ROI, etc., are set at the outset and rigorously tracked). But equally, it aims to leave your organization *better equipped*

to handle future changes on its own. By instilling a culture of evidence-based decision-making, empathy, and continuous learning, CLEAR creates internal capability. In other words, your team not only solves the problem at hand, but also *learns to fish* – adopting behaviours and mindsets that will benefit future initiatives.

In summation, the CLEAR Change Framework can be seen as the **foundation of a house**: OBM, BCW, and Design Thinking are excellent rooms or wings within that house, each with their purpose. But without a solid foundation tying them together, you'd have separate structures. CLEAR is that foundation and the architectural plan that connects interventions, ensuring the whole house stands solid against the winds of change. It invites you to not just change one element of your organization, but to **transform holistically** – with clarity (no pun intended), purpose, and humanity.

If you are exploring change methodology partnerships, consider CLEAR not as a bet on an unproven idea, but as a **synthesis of the best in the field**. It is the broader horizon where behaviour management, behavioural science, and human-centered design meet and reinforce each other. By partnering with Erik Bohjort and employing the CLEAR framework, you position your organization to harness **the full spectrum of change tools under one expert-guided approach**. The result? Change that is not only successfully implemented, but *sustained* – change that resonates with your people, aligns with your strategy, and adapts with your context. In a world rife with one-note solutions, CLEAR offers a symphony – one that can inspire, guide, and deliver the transformative results you seek.

Sources: The insights and comparisons in this paper draw on established research and practice in behavior science and design. Notable references include definitions of OBM

bacb.com en.wikipedia.org, the comprehensive structure of the Behavior Change Wheel pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov

pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov, and the human-centered ethos of Design Thinking online.hbs.edu online.hbs.edu, as well as Erik Bohjort's own perspectives on change processes and behavior change from his experience in the field. These sources highlight that CLEAR is built upon proven foundations while offering a new integrative vision.